At a Loss

By Dan Savage

The strangest thing about returning to the scene of the crime is that so many involve somebody returning to a place he really doesn't want to go. Someplace that he dislikes, or disagrees with, or wished he'd never been in the first place. But then the person finds that he can't help himself, he goes back. The crime scene in this story is a Catholic church. And yes, I went to Catholic grade schools. And yes, I was an altar boy. But no, the crime is not what you're assuming. No Catholic school children were harmed during the production of this story. So you can relax.

INTRODUCTION

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I am no longer a practicing Catholic. If I had to apply a religious label to myself, it would be "agnostatheist, an awkward hybrid of agnostic and atheist. I don't believe in a higher power, but I do cross myself on airplanes. I once blew up at a friend who thought he was being funny when he inverted one of the crucifixes in my "ironic" collection of Catholic kitsch. And when I take the Lord's name in vain - when I mutter "Jesus Christ" through clenched teeth as my lead-footed husband passes someone going ninety miles an hour -- I am seeking the protection of a higher power.

But I go right back to not believing once my plane safely lands or once Jesus or Joseph Smith or Xenu safely delivers us back to the right-hand lane. Which makes me a hypocrite and an ingrate, I suppose, but not quite an atheist or a believer. Not quite.

I wasn't supposed to turn out this way. I went to the same Catholic grade school my mother and grandmother did. I was baptized as an infant; I had my first communion at age seven; I was confirmed at age thirteen.

But even at age seven, I was having trouble reconciling this "loving father in heaven" with this "eternal damnation" thing the nuns were constantly threatening us with. But the fatal blow was the realization that I was gay. This realization came at roughly the same time I entered a Catholic high school for boys who were thinking about becoming priests. It was a bit like realizing you're an alcoholic on your first day working at the Budweiser bottling plant.

Despite all those years of Catholic schooling, my first reaction to the realization that I was gay wasn't, "Looks like I'm going to find out what that eternal damnation thing is all about." Instead I thought, "What the church says about homosexuality – that can't be right. They must be wrong." This intuitive sense that the Church was wrong about homosexuality - - this unshakable conviction that the Church was wrong about *me* – led me to wonder what else the Church might be wrong about. Virgin births, maybe? Resurrection? Masturbation? It didn't take long to arrive at the biggest doubt of all: The existence of God.

I transferred to a public high school and stopped going to church – except for the odd family wedding, baptism or funeral. (And they are all odd, aren't they?) For most of my adult live I was likelier to walk into a Planned Parenthood clinic for a Pap smear than to walk into a church.

Then my mother died.

A virus can lay dormant in your body for so long that you can forget you were ever infected. Then something happens that weakens your immune system and the virus seizes its opportunity. For more than two decades the Catholicism I'd contracted at Saint Ignatius had lain dormant, manifesting itself only on airplanes and in passing lanes. But the immunity I'd long enjoyed was weakened by my mother's death. Because after that sunny, awful day in Tucson, Arizona, when my mother's life ended, I started slipping into Catholic

churches. Not for weddings or funerals, but on totally random days of non-holy, non-obligation. Tuesday afternoons, Friday mornings. And I wasn't just going to church. I was going out of my way to go to church.

Saint James Cathedral in downtown Seattle looks like a Catholic church should – Acres of stained glass, rows of marble columns, crowds of plaster saints. Saint James is open for "private contemplation " several days a week. The church was usually empty, aside from one or two volunteers straightening up the hymnals and the offering envelopes in the backs of the pews. I think they were really there to keep an eye on the homeless people that sometimes come in to get out of the rain. Every once in a while a priest would hurry through, taking care to avoid making eye contact with me or any of the other bums.

When my mother used to call with bad news-- a relative I hadn't seen in years diagnosed with cancer, an old friend with a desperately ill grandchild-- she would always say, "I know you don't pray, Daniel. Just keep them in your thoughts." My mom knew that thoughts were the best I could do. And for months after my mother's death, sitting in the pews at Saint James Cathedral, I stared at a marble statue of the Virgin Mother, trying to keep my mother in my thoughts.

By her own estimation my mother was a good Catholic. She believed that Jesus was her savior and that He died for her sins; she believed in the Resurrection, the Virgin Birth, The Trinity, the Sacraments. My mother also believed that sex was sacred, and that people, particularly people with children, should be married. To each other. But she didn't believe that being a good Catholic meant blind obedience. You could say that my mother was a good American Catholic. She believed that women should be priests. And that priests, male or female, should be allowed to marry. And after four pregnancies in four years, my mother concluded that birth control was not a sin.

My mother prayed that the leaders of her church would come around during her lifetime. Unfortunately, the Church, under the last two popes, moved further away from her. Whenever the current pope, "Benny", as she called him, or the previous pope, "JP2", condemned birth control, attacked gay people, or insisted that women could never be ordained as priests, my mother would call me, sigh audibly, and say, "It's like they're trying to make Lutherans of us all."

But she refused to leave the church. It was her church, too, she insisted, just as much as it was Benny's, or JP2's. The little voice in her head said the same thing the little voice in mine did: "That can't be right, they must be wrong." But that voice, a voice that destroyed my faith, somehow strengthened hers. [She] took it hard when I told her I was gay. Her first impulse was to call a priest. Father Tom, whose last name I won't disclose for reasons that will become clear in a moment, rushed over. Sitting on the front porch, my mother broke down in tears and told Father Tom why she was so upset: "Danny says he's gay."

Father Tom put his hand on my mother's knee and said, "So am I."

My mother came around on the my-son-is-gay issue pretty fast. And she came out swinging. A rainbow bumper sticker on her car, a PFLAG membership, and an ultimatum delivered to the entire extended family: I was still her son; and anyone who had a problem with me had a much bigger problem with her.

The Catholic Church still has a problem with me.

One of the cards in the back of the pews at Saint James, tucked in with the hymnals, is addressed to non-practicing Catholics. "WELCOME BACK" it reads in large letters across the top.

Are you a Catholic who's been away from the church?
Welcome back classes are designed to help you return to the
sacraments and regular church attendance.

A return to the sacraments. I sometimes fantasize about "returning" to the sacraments, particularly the sacrament of confession. "Forgive me father, for I have sinned. It's been twenty-nine years since my last confession. I hope you packed a lunch."

I want there to be heaven. And I want my mother to be looking down on me. Though, and I say this both as a gay man and a professional sex advice columnist, *not all the time*. There are things a mother has a right not to know – and I did my best to keep those things from her while she was alive. My mother's death, somehow and unexpectedly, drew me back to church. I was tempted. I am tempted. I wouldn't have wasted so much time sitting in Saint James in the months after my mother's death if I weren't. My husband would not have found a "WELCOME BACK" card in the back pocket of my jeans if I weren't tempted.

But when I feel tempted, when I feel like, maybe, I could go through the motions, maybe I could return to the sacraments, maybe I could take what comfort I could from the Church and its rituals, the pope goes to Africa and says that condoms spread AIDS, or an archbishop in Brazil excommunicates a Catholic mother for getting her nine-year-old daughter a life-saving abortion, but not the Catholic man who raped and impregnated that woman's nine-year-old daughter.

Or I contemplate how the church views me and the two people I love most in the world, my husband of eighteen years and our fifteen-year-old son, and I think, no, I can't even go through the motions.

The Church doesn't want me back – not as I am. Every other week there's a story in the news about a Catholic grade school expelling a child who has gay parents. When it comes to homosexuality, church leaders are growing ever more, er, rigid. The Church condemns homosexuality as "intrinsically and gravely disordered." So long as we insist on coming out,

so long as we insist on living and loving openly, our "sin" is visible to the naked eye. And Church leaders can't see past our homosexuality; they can barely see our *humanity*.

[And yet I still] want there to be heaven. And I want my mother to be looking down on me. [And I still] sit in the pews at Saint James Cathedral, staring at a marble statue of the Virgin Mother, trying to keep my mother in my thoughts.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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